

DIVERS

These web-footed, fish-eating birds of Arctic waters have rear-set legs that limit their movement on land but provide excellent thrust for swimming.

Divers are the only family in the order Gaviiformes. The alternative name for these birds – loon – may originate from their haunting “lunatic” wailing cries uttered during the breeding season, or possibly from their ungainly motion when out of water. A diver’s legs are set so far back on the body that the bird can only manage an awkward shuffle on land. In water, divers swim and dive with ease. Their streamlined body and spear-like bill closely resemble those of penguins, which have similar habits – it is possible, though not certain, that these birds may share a common ancestor.

Although their pointed wings are relatively small for their body size, divers are fast fliers. To get themselves airborne, the larger species have to patter across open water; only the red-throated diver is able to take off from land. All species fly southwards to overwinter.

SHARED PARENTING
Territorial male divers choose nest sites in vegetation on the shores of clear Arctic lakes, where both sexes incubate and tend the young. Young diver chicks ride on the backs of their parents, but they can swim and even dive soon after hatching. After breeding, divers lose their striking head and neck patterns, and their duller body plumage makes it more difficult to distinguish the different species.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	GAVIIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	5



Divers fly with their outstretched head held slightly lower than the body, which gives them a hunchbacked appearance.



GREAT NORTHERN DIVER
Gavia immer
F: Gaviidae

One of the largest divers, this bird breeds on lakes in subarctic regions of N. America and Iceland. It overwinters on coasts further south, including those around Britain.

69–91 cm
27–36 in

striped
neck patch

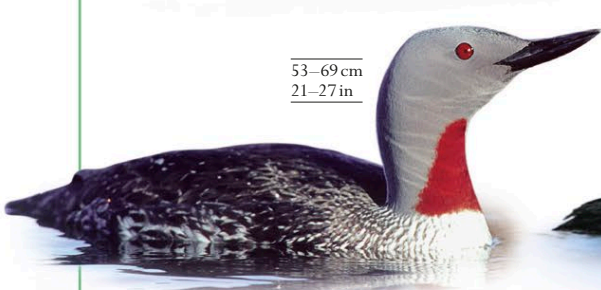
black head
and neck



WHITE-BILLED DIVER
Gavia adamsii
F: Gaviidae

A large species of Arctic waters, this white-billed bird can be distinguished from other divers by its yellowish white bill.

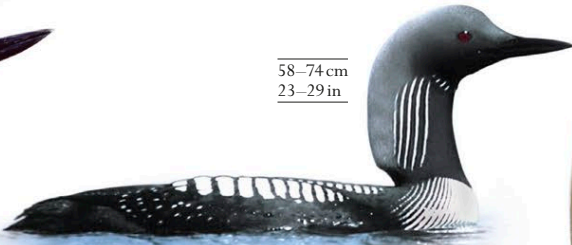
76–91 cm
30–36 in



53–69 cm
21–27 in

RED-THROATED DIVER
Gavia stellata
F: Gaviidae

The smallest diver, this bird breeds on small tundra pools in circumpolar regions and migrates south to Europe, China, and the southeastern USA to overwinter.

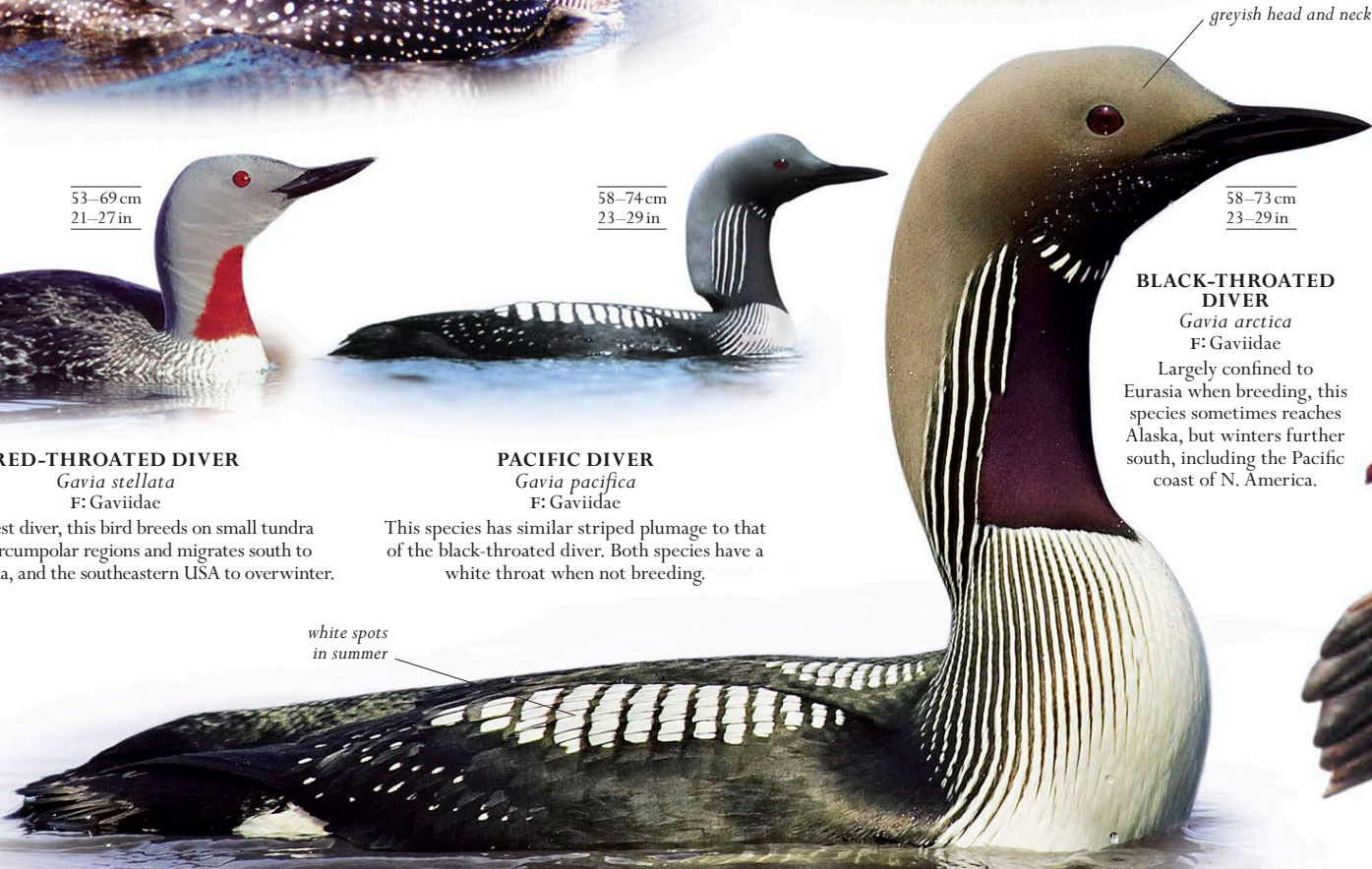


58–74 cm
23–29 in

PACIFIC DIVER
Gavia pacifica
F: Gaviidae

This species has similar striped plumage to that of the black-throated diver. Both species have a white throat when not breeding.

white spots
in summer



greyish head and neck

BLACK-THROATED DIVER
Gavia arctica
F: Gaviidae

Largely confined to Eurasia when breeding, this species sometimes reaches Alaska, but winters further south, including the Pacific coast of N. America.

58–73 cm
23–29 in

